Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2020)

I. Governance and Purpose

The USA Pickleball Association (USAPA) and the International Federation of Pickleball (IFP) serve as the governing bodies for the sport [cite: 1, 2, 3]. Their combined mission is to perpetuate the growth and advancement of pickleball internationally and to set goals for worldwide play and recognition [cite: 1, 2, 3]. These organizations are committed to the growth and development of the sport across all player levels [cite: 1, 2, 3].

II. Court and Equipment Standards

A standard pickleball court is a rectangle measuring 20 feet (6.10 m) by 44 feet (13.41 m) for both singles and doubles play [cite: 1, 2, 3]. The court is divided by a net that is 36 inches (0.914 m) high at the sidelines and 34 inches (0.86 m) at the center [cite: 1, 2, 3]. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ), also known as the 'kitchen,' extends 7 feet from the net on both sides [cite: 1, 2, 3]. Official paddles must be made of a rigid, non-compressible material with a smooth surface; the combined length and width cannot exceed 24 inches [cite: 1, 2, 3]. The ball is a hollow plastic sphere with between 26 and 40 circular holes [cite: 1, 2, 3].

III. Service and Double-Bounce Rules

Service Mechanics

The serve must be hit underhand, with the paddle contacting the ball below the waist [cite: 1, 2, 3]. At the time of impact, the server's arm must be moving in an upward arc, and the highest point of the paddle head must be below the wrist [cite: 1, 2, 3]. The server must have both feet behind the baseline at the point of contact and must serve diagonally to the opposite service court [cite: 1, 2, 3].

Two-Bounce Rule

The ball must bounce once on each side of the court before any volleys are allowed [cite: 1, 2, 3]. The receiving team must play the serve off the bounce, and the serving team must play the return of the serve off the bounce [cite: 1, 2, 3]. After these two bounces have occurred, both teams may either volley the ball or play it off the bounce [cite: 1, 2, 3].

IV. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ)

Volleying is prohibited within the non-volley zone [cite: 1, 2, 3]. It is a fault if the player, their clothing, or their paddle touches the NVZ or its lines during the act of volleying [cite: 1,

2, 3]. The 2020 rules specify that if a player's momentum causes them to touch the NVZ after hitting a volley, even if the ball is declared dead before the contact occurs, it is still a fault [cite: 1, 2, 3]. A player may be in the NVZ at any time except when volleying the ball [cite: 1, 2, 3].

V. Scoring Systems

Doubles Scoring:
* Points are scored only by the serving team [cite: 1, 2, 3].
* The score is called as three numbers: Server Score, Receiver Score, and the Server Number (1 or 2) [cite: 1, 2, 3].
* At the start of each game, only one partner on the first serving team is allowed to serve before a side-out [cite: 1, 2, 3].

Singles Scoring:
* The score is called as two numbers: Server Score and Receiver Score [cite: 1, 2, 3].
* The server serves from the right court when their score is even and from the left court when their score is odd [cite: 1, 2, 3].

VI. Faults and Dead Balls

A fault results in a loss of the serve or a point for the opposing team [cite: 1, 2, 3]. Common faults include hitting the ball into the net, hitting the ball out of bounds, failing to clear the NVZ on a serve, or violating the double-bounce rule [cite: 1, 2, 3]. A ball that touches any permanent object (such as a fence or light post) before bouncing is also considered a fault [cite: 1, 2, 3].